

THE LOWERY INSTITUTE CHANGE AGENT PROGRAM
FOOD INSECURITY CAPSTONE

THE STUDENT NUTRITION AND ACCESS REFORM ACT



Addressing the
growing issue of
Food Insecurity
on College
Campuses



I. Organizational Background

Established in 2001, the Joseph and Evelyn Lowery Institute for Justice and Human Rights is dedicated to training, developing, empowering, and inspiring leaders to improve their communities for the common good. The Institute serves this mission by focusing on the following areas: education, civic engagement, social justice, and community health locally, nationally, and abroad.

The Lowery Institute Scholar Activist Capstone is a national yearlong social justice opportunity for students currently enrolled full-time in an accredited higher education academic institution. Students develop and exhibit academic and leadership skills in the pursuit of advancing social justice causes by examining issues that disproportionately affect people of color across the United States. These students, or change agents, put learning into practice and work in small teams on a substantive, policy-oriented project.

Over the past three years, students from college campuses across the United States, including Clark Atlanta University, Howard University, Spelman College, Morehouse College, Miles College, Edward Waters College, and Stillman college have conducted research on collegiate food insecurity and created 'The Student Nutrition and Access Reform Act' to meet the challenges of food insecurity. The following legislative proposal explains the need for this bill and the changes this potential legislation will achieve.

Bill Text

Background of Issue:

The current Farm Bill doesn't provide long-term, effective solutions to food insecurity in the United States specifically on college campuses. While it offers food assistance (such as SNAP benefits) to qualifying individuals, the program lacks critical things. This includes limited nutritional options in which SNAP benefits often do not cover sufficient fresh fruits, vegetables, and other nutrient foods which leads to poor dietary health among low-income communities. In addition to this, the bill has an overly restrictive eligibility criteria where many individuals in need, including college students, are excluded from receiving benefits due to outdated household income calculations. For example, students who live independently but are still considered part of their parents' household are frequently denied assistance, despite facing food insecurity. Finally, one of the main things that the farm bill fails to consider is food deserts & accessibility – Many low-income communities lack access to affordable, nutritious food, especially in Historically Black Colleges and Institutes.

Most of these institutes are located in major cities where there is a lack of food accessibility or rural and suburban areas where there isn't an adequate public transport system. An example of this is Howard University, which is in Washington D.C., lacks affordable food choices as the closest dollar general is 40 minutes away and the closest grocery store is Whole Foods, a high-end supermarket. Another example of food inaccessibility include the institutions that comprise the Atlanta University Center, including Clark Atlanta University, Morehouse College, and Spelman College, located in Atlanta, Georgia, where the nearest grocery store is 1.9 miles from the campus.

The Farm Bill and other existing legislation does not adequately address these systemic barriers. Students across the country are suffering from food insecurity. Over 40% of college students state

that they face food insecurity. This issue can't be ignored and change is needed. Many people struggle to access these benefits, including low-income families struggling to afford healthy food. Other people affected are college students particularly at HBCUs and community colleges, who often face food insecurity due to financial constraints, people who earn just above the SNAP eligibility criteria but still struggle with food costs and people in food deserts with limited access to grocery stores offering fresh produces

Previously Existing legislation and History of attempts to solve problem

Previous legislative efforts, such as H.R.8467 - Farm, Food, and the National Security Act of 2024, have maintained restrictive eligibility requirements and insufficient nutritional support. While some states have implemented pilot programs to expand SNAP access for college students, these policies do not adequately meet the needs of the populations they seek to affect. Students face challenges qualifying for SNAP through restrictive employment and income requirements

Justification for Policy Change:

The current Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) income and work requirements place unnecessary burdens on individuals who need food assistance the most. These restrictions disproportionately harm low-income individuals, students, and working families who may not fit the rigid criteria set by policymakers. Additionally, they fail to address larger systemic issues like food deserts, where individuals—especially students in low-income areas—lack access to fresh and affordable groceries. SNAP's income thresholds are outdated and fail to account for the true cost of living.

While eligibility is determined by the federal poverty level (FPL), this measure does not reflect regional cost differences or inflation rates. Many individuals who struggle to afford food are deemed ineligible simply because their income is slightly above the threshold, despite high expenses such as tuition, rent, and healthcare. For students, this issue is particularly pressing, as many juggle tuition costs while working low-wage jobs that barely cover their living expenses. Without SNAP benefits, students in food deserts are left with even fewer options—relying on overpriced, processed foods from convenience stores because affordable grocery stores with fresh fruits and vegetables are too far away.

Work Requirements:

Work requirements impose unnecessary barriers to accessing food assistance. Currently, non-disabled adults without dependents must work at least 20 hours per week to maintain benefits. This requirement disproportionately affects students, part-time workers, and those in unstable job markets. College students are often forced to work excessive hours just to qualify for assistance, which can negatively impact their academic performance. Moreover, these requirements ignore the reality of inconsistent work schedules with college students, neglecting the hours they spend working in class or on academic work, which is their primary job. SNAP requirements need to be redesigned to designate hours spent on coursework.

To address these issues, The Student Nutrition and Access Reform Act proposes the following changes to SNAP eligibility:

1. Definition of College Food Security

The USDA should create an official federal definition of “college food security.” This definition should be informed by the existing USDA 18-item Household Food Security Survey Module, which categorizes individuals as having high, marginal, low, or very low food security. Adapting this validated framework specifically for college students will allow for more accurate monitoring and clearer identification of student food insecurity. College students, especially those at Historically Black Colleges and Universities (HBCUs) and other minority-serving institutions, face unique financial, environmental, and accessibility constraints. Establishing a student-focused definition is essential for improving data collection, strengthening SNAP eligibility reforms, and supporting grant programs aimed at reducing campus food insecurity.

2. Eliminate Work Hour Requirements for Students –

Allow college students to qualify for SNAP based on income and financial need alone, rather than requiring them to meet strict work requirements. Modify existing legislation so that collegiate course hours can be used as a substitute for 20 hour work requirements. Students would submit transcripts from accredited institutions as evidence of meeting requirements.

3. Create C-EBT Program

Creating a College Electronic Benefit Transfer Program (C-EBT) modeled after the Pandemic EBT (P-EBT) system, providing monthly electronic benefits to eligible college students to support essential living costs such as groceries, hygiene products, and basic supplies. Eligibility includes domestic students from low-income households, Pell Grant recipients, first-generation students, and international students on valid student visas who demonstrate financial need. The distribution model adapts the P-EBT framework: state agencies would use existing data systems, such as FAFSA records, financial aid information, and student enrollment databases to identify eligible students automatically. Benefits would be loaded monthly onto EBT cards or digital wallets, mirroring the proven P-EBT process that utilized SNAP and school meal data to deliver direct support. By leveraging the infrastructure already used during the pandemic, C-EBT offers a scalable and efficient method for supporting students’ essential needs while enrolled in higher education.

4. Adjust Income Limits Based on Regional Cost of Living –

Update SNAP income requirements to no longer classify student scholarships, loans, and grants as income. would be required to report income that comes as the result of direct paid employment.

5. Expand Eligibility for Students –

Broaden the definition of "eligible students" to include those who are financially independent or come from low-income families, making it easier for them to access food assistance. College students with student visas can qualify as alien status allowing them to apply for SNAP.

6. Establish Small Business and Corporate Grant Program

Create a grant and pass tax credits to incentivize corporations and small businesses to open grocery stores within 1 mile of collegiate institutions. Additional grants can be created for new grocery stores opened near Historically Black Colleges and Universities.

7. Establish Collegiate Grant Program

Create a grant for colleges to create campus food pantries and grocery stores on their campuses that students could use SNAP or other methods of funding to purchase foods.